

Consumer Complaints Dataset

A paragraph-based explanation of the file's structure, coverage, major patterns, and representative records.

The CSV file contains **555,957 consumer complaint records** arranged across **18 columns**. Each row describes one complaint and connects the date it was received, the financial product and issue involved, the company named by the consumer, location and submission details, the company's response, whether the response was timely, whether the consumer disputed that response, and a unique complaint identifier. The file covers complaints received from **December 01, 2011** through **April 25, 2016**.

The structure is consistent throughout the file. Every parsed record contains exactly 18 fields, both date columns use the MM/DD/YYYY format and parse successfully, and every complaint_id value is populated and unique. This makes complaint_id the appropriate row-level key. The zipcode field should remain text rather than a number because converting it to a numeric value could remove leading zeroes.

Because the source contains more than half a million rows, reproducing every record in a PDF would create an extremely large and difficult-to-use document. This report therefore explains the full dataset in paragraph form and includes representative records in prose, while the CSV remains the authoritative source for row-level analysis.

How the columns are organized

Dates and identification

The `date_received` column records when the complaint entered the system, while `date_sent_to_company` records when it was forwarded to the named company. Both fields are complete. The `complaint_id` column is a unique identifier for each complaint and contains 555,957 distinct values, matching the total row count. Although `complaint_id` contains digits, it should be treated as an identifier rather than a measurable quantity.

Complaint classification

The `product` column assigns every complaint to one of 11 broad financial-product categories. The `sub_product` column adds a more specific classification when one is available and is populated for 397,635 records (71.52%). The `issue` column is complete and contains 95 distinct issue categories. The `sub_issue` column provides finer detail for 212,622 complaints (38.24%). Blank sub-product and sub-issue values should be treated as unavailable detail, not as a separate complaint type.

Narrative and public response text

The `consumer_complaint_narrative` column stores the consumer's written description when publication consent and data availability permit it. It is populated for 66,806 records (12.02%) and can contain long text and embedded line breaks. The `company_public_response` column is populated for 85,124 records (15.31%) and contains 10 response categories or statements. These text fields must remain correctly quoted when the data is exported or transformed.

Company, location, and consumer context

The `company` column is complete and names 3,605 distinct companies. The `state` column uses two-character state or territory codes and is populated for 551,070 records (99.12%). The `zipcode` column is populated for 551,452 records (99.19%). The `tags` column identifies consumers tagged as Older American, Servicemember, or both, and is populated for 77,959 records (14.02%). The `consumer_consent_provided` column records narrative-publication consent status and is populated for 123,458 records (22.21%).

Submission and outcomes

The `submitted_via` column records the intake channel and is complete for all complaints. The `company_response_to_consumer` column records the response or closure outcome and is also complete. The `timely_response` column indicates whether the company responded on time using Yes or No values. The `consumer_disputed?` column records whether the consumer disputed the company's response and also uses Yes or No values. These fields form the core workflow and outcome section of each complaint record.

What the data shows

Product mix

The largest product categories are Mortgage with 186,475 records (33.54%), Debt collection with 101,052 records (18.18%), Credit reporting with 91,854 records (16.52%), Credit card with 66,468 records (11.96%), Bank account or service with 62,563 records (11.25%), Consumer Loan with 20,990 records (3.78%), and Student loan with 15,839 records (2.85%). Together, these categories show that mortgages, debt collection, credit reporting, credit cards, and bank-account services dominate the complaint file.

Common issues

The most common complaint issues are Loan modification, collection, foreclosure with 97,191 records (17.48%), Incorrect information on credit report with 66,718 records (12.00%), Loan servicing, payments, escrow account with 60,375 records (10.86%), Cont'd attempts collect debt not owed with 42,285 records (7.61%), Account opening, closing, or management with 26,661 records (4.80%), Communication tactics with 18,293 records (3.29%), and Disclosure verification of debt with 18,292 records (3.29%). The concentration of complaints in loan modification, credit-report accuracy, loan servicing, and debt-collection disputes indicates that account administration and information accuracy are recurring themes in the dataset.

Companies and geography

The companies with the highest record counts are Bank of America with 55,998 records (10.07%), Wells Fargo & Company with 42,024 records (7.56%), JPMorgan Chase & Co. with 33,881 records (6.09%), Equifax with 31,828 records (5.72%), Experian with 30,905 records (5.56%), Citibank with 25,540 records (4.59%), and TransUnion Intermediate Holdings, Inc. with 25,534 records (4.59%). The leading state codes are CA with 81,700 records (14.70%), FL with 53,673 records (9.65%), TX with 41,352 records (7.44%), NY with 38,266 records (6.88%), GA with 24,548 records (4.42%), NJ with 22,408 records (4.03%), and PA with 20,015 records (3.60%). These are raw complaint counts and should not be interpreted as rates without adjusting for company size, customer base, state population, or product exposure.

Submission channels and company responses

Complaints were submitted through Web with 361,338 records (64.99%), Referral with 109,379 records (19.67%), Phone with 40,026 records (7.20%), Postal mail with 36,752 records (6.61%), Fax with 8,118 records (1.46%), and Email with 344 records (0.06%). Company outcomes were led by Closed with explanation with 404,293 records (72.72%), Closed with non-monetary relief with 70,237 records (12.63%), Closed with monetary relief with 38,262 records (6.88%), Closed without relief with 17,909 records (3.22%), Closed with 13,399 records (2.41%), Closed with relief with 5,305 records (0.95%), and In progress with 3,763 records (0.68%). The `timely_response` field reports Yes for 541,909 complaints (97.47%) and No for 14,048 complaints (2.53%). The `consumer_disputed?` field reports Yes for 112,134 complaints (20.17%) and No for 443,823 complaints (79.83%).

Completeness and quality observations

The fully populated fields are date_received, product, issue, company, submitted_via, date_sent_to_company, company_response_to_consumer, timely_response, consumer_disputed?, and complaint_id. State and zipcode are nearly complete, with 4,887 blank state values (0.88%) and 4,505 blank ZIP-code values (0.81%). Sub-product is missing for 158,322 records (28.48%), while sub-issue is missing for 343,335 records (61.76%).

The most sparsely populated field is consumer_complaint_narrative, which is blank for 489,151 records (87.98%). The tags field is blank for 477,998 records (85.98%), company_public_response is blank for 470,833 records (84.69%), and consumer_consent_provided is blank for 432,499 records (77.79%). These blanks largely reflect optional fields or publication conditions rather than broken CSV structure.

The time between receipt and forwarding has a median of 1 day and a mean of 4.66 days. Observed values range from -1 to 993 days. There are 7,057 records with a negative calculated delay, meaning the date sent to the company precedes the recorded receipt date. These values do not indicate malformed CSV rows, but they should be reviewed before the dataset is used for operational timing analysis. The unusually large maximum delay should also be treated as a potential outlier requiring record-level investigation.

For analysis, missing optional fields should remain null rather than being converted to zero. Complaint counts should be clearly distinguished from complaint rates, and any comparison among companies or states should use an appropriate denominator. Text analysis should use consumer_complaint_narrative only when its missingness and publication-consent conditions are considered.

Representative records written as paragraphs

The following paragraphs restate the first five CSV rows in readable prose. Narrative text is not present in these five records, so the paragraphs describe the compact classification and outcome fields.

Complaint **511074** was received on 08/30/2013. It concerned **Mortgage** under the sub-product Other mortgage and reported the issue **Loan modification, collection, foreclosure**. The company was **U.S. Bancorp**, the state was CA, and the complaint was submitted by Referral. It was sent to the company on 09/03/2013. The recorded company response was Closed with explanation. Timely response was marked Yes, and consumer dispute was marked Yes.

Complaint **511080** was received on 08/30/2013. It concerned **Mortgage** under the sub-product Other mortgage and reported the issue **Loan servicing, payments, escrow account**. The company was **Wells Fargo & Company**, the state was CA, and the complaint was submitted by Referral. It was sent to the company on 09/03/2013. The recorded company response was Closed with explanation. Timely response was marked Yes, and consumer dispute was marked Yes.

Complaint **510473** was received on 08/30/2013. It concerned **Credit reporting** and reported the issue **Incorrect information on credit report**. The recorded sub-issue was Account status. The company was **Wells Fargo & Company**, the state was NY, and the complaint was submitted by Postal mail. It was sent to the company on 09/18/2013. The recorded company response was Closed with explanation. Timely response was marked Yes, and consumer dispute was marked No.

Complaint **510326** was received on 08/30/2013. It concerned **Student loan** under the sub-product Non-federal student loan and reported the issue **Repaying your loan**. The recorded sub-issue was Repaying your loan. The company was **Navient Solutions, Inc.**, the state was MD, and the complaint was submitted by Email. It was sent to the company on 08/30/2013. The recorded company response was Closed with explanation. Timely response was marked Yes, and consumer dispute was marked Yes.

Complaint **511067** was received on 08/30/2013. It concerned **Debt collection** under the sub-product Credit card and reported the issue **False statements or representation**. The recorded sub-issue was Attempted to collect wrong amount. The company was **Resurgent Capital Services L.P.**, the state was GA, and the complaint was submitted by Web. It was sent to the company on 08/30/2013. The recorded company response was Closed with explanation. Timely response was marked Yes, and consumer dispute was marked Yes.

Recommended use

Use `date_received`, `product`, `issue`, `company`, and `state` to analyze complaint volume. Use `date_sent_to_company`, `company_response_to_consumer`, and `timely_response` to examine workflow outcomes. Use `consumer_disputed?` with `product`, `issue`, `company`, and `state` to study disputed responses. Use `consumer_complaint_narrative` for text analysis only after accounting for its high missing rate and the consent field. Use `complaint_id` for joins, deduplication, and traceability.